

iron and munitions industries to equip it. By 1725, Russia had a professional army of 130,000 men.

A new and modern culture

Peter transformed his court, making his courtiers adopt French-style dress instead of traditional robes, and ordering them to cut off their long beards. He founded colleges, forced the nobility to educate their children, and promoted people to high rank according to their merit rather than their birth, as had previously been the case.

The emperor was also known for his harsh treatment of rebels, his aggressive foreign policy, and particularly for his successful war against Sweden, which gave him control of the Baltic Sea. This style of rule was continued under later monarchs, notably Catherine II, also “the Great,” who extended the modernizing trend Peter had begun. Influenced by the ideas of the European Enlightenment, she promoted education and the arts, sponsored translations of foreign literary works, and wrote books herself. She, too, increased Russia's imperial strength, gaining military victories over the Ottoman Empire.

The rulers were also influenced by the example of Prussia, a north-German state that expanded in the 18th century due to

Peter I visits **Western Europe**, absorbing **ideas and influences**.

Contemporary theories of rulership provide a **model of enlightened despotism**.

Baroque western palaces and **cities demonstrate their rulers' power**.

Peter founds St. Petersburg as the capital of a Westernized Russian empire.

an efficient bureaucracy, a powerful army, and strong leadership under kings such as Frederick II. Between Prussia and Russia lay Poland, whose territories these two powers and Austria carved up and took over in a series of partitions. This left Russia with influence over an area stretching from Eastern Europe to Siberia that it still largely retains today. ■

Peter the Great



Peter (1672–1725) became ruler of Russia in 1682, at first jointly with his half-brother Ivan as co-czar and their mother

as regent, and then as sole monarch. Well-educated and constantly curious, Peter traveled to the Netherlands and England to learn about Western life, government, and architecture. He also studied disciplines such as shipbuilding and woodworking, and practiced many with distinction. His rule was greatly influenced by these travels and by Western advisers, leading him to carry out military reforms and adopt a dictatorial style of rule. The position and grand architecture of

his new city illustrated how his focus had been directed toward Western European culture and power.

Although Peter forged lasting diplomatic ties with Western Europe, he failed in his attempt to form a European alliance against the Ottomans. He was more successful in his war against Sweden, his reforms, and in establishing himself as emperor of a vast empire and monarchy that survived until the revolution in 1917.